

Postproverbial Variations among Youths in Southwest Nigeria: Culture Shift, Value Shift or Linguistic Creativity?

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Abstract

Research has focused attention on proverbs and, of recent, on postproverbials. More recent is the recognition of the patterns referred to as 'postproverbial variations' in this paper. This paper interrogates postproverbial variations and examines the motivations for it among youths in Southwest Nigeria. Driven by Raji-Oyelade's notion of postproverbiality and Ehala's Ethnolinguistic Vitality Theory (2015), data comprises ten (10) incomplete proverbs, purposively selected and presented to 361 Yoruba-speaking participants among university undergraduates in three states in southwestern Nigeria. Respondents were to complete the proverbs and, indicate their source/motivation for the choice of the completive postproverbials. Data analysis establishes that postproverbials lend themselves to variations in the hands of the youths and, that postproverbials vary widely along socio-pragmatic dimensions. Postproverbials are heavily influenced by popular youth culture and by the individual value of the speaker in specific contexts (social media, peers and self), while its formation shows profuse evidence of linguistic creativity. The paper maintains that postproverbial variations exist as a direct result of constant shifts in the individual values of the youths and, influenced by popular youth cultures of the society as the youths employ them as identity markers, sustaining and preserving the language and its proverbs.

Key words: Proverbs, postproverbial variations, creativity, youth culture, social media.

Introduction

Among the Yoruba people of Southwest Nigeria, proverbs occupy a position of supreme rhetorical authority, no wonder they say: *òwè lẹ̀ sìn ọ̀ rọ̀* (proverbs are the pillars of speech). These compressed wisdom statements function not merely as decorative language but as vehicles of jurisprudence, pedagogy, and intergenerational communication. To speak without proverbs, it is said, is to speak without evidence. For centuries, the integrity of these proverbs remained largely inviolate, they were transmitted vertically from elders to youths as fixed, sacrosanct texts whose modification was neither permissible nor imaginable. However, contemporary sociolinguistic reality in Southwest Nigeria presents a striking departure from this tradition. Across urban centres, and increasingly within digital spaces occupied by Yoruba-speaking youths, a new linguistic practice emerged: the deliberate alteration, truncation, or subversion of canonical proverbs. This practice raises urgent questions about the state of oral tradition, the agency of young speakers, and the resilience of Yoruba philosophy in the face of modernity and globalization. Eckert posits that adolescents "are the linguistic movers and shakers...and, as such, a prime source of information about linguistic change and the role of language in social practice" (1997, p. 52).

This is because youths are the most innovative and creative language users. Such linguistic innovation and creativity among youths are enhanced by their early exposure to, and adoption of, communicative technologies, vibrant youth culture, peculiar social forces, and their propensity for experimentation with new forms. Many scholars have recognised that youths' linguistic practices are rich empirical ground for understanding language variation and change. No wonder scholars in Africa too have concentrated research efforts to studying creativity, innovations, identity, culture, communication technologies and strategies in the language of the youths. Some of such studies include Carado and Germe (2025) which examine the influence of cultural trends, social media, prestige considerations, and societal influences on the use of slang language among Generation Z students in a secondary school. Nsahwir, Chie and Mbibeh (2025) analyse how youth culture, mediated through social media, peer interactions, and local communities, fosters the emergence of neologisms. The findings reveal that neologism reflect broader socio-political and cultural dynamics, and serve as markers of youth identity, marking belongingness, differentiation and gender focus.

Kunzmann (2024) examines whether the similarities and differences observed between two African youth languages can be addressed by determining the linguistic strategies employed by speakers to innovate. The paper argues that although both strategies -- combining two or more resources from different languages in the speaker's linguistic repertoire, and using a linguistic strategy with a part of the speaker's linguistic repertoire -- may occur simultaneously, Yanké speakers rely more on combining different languages from their repertoire, while Langila speakers rely more on applying creative language games to their repertoire. Lastly, Mensah (2012) examines the sociolinguistic import of an emerging hybrid street language by the Ágábá Boys in Calabar South in Nigeria by exploring the ingroup code which is manifested in slang, metaphors and a variety of taboo expressions embodied in expletives, profanities, insults, curses and swear words. Findings reveal that the codes are used to reinforce anti-establishment behaviour, conceptualize identity, enhance solidarity and foster group integration.

Studies in African proverbs have shown that the propensity of youths to reorder or transform language does not neglect the areas of proverbs and proverbial studies. In these studies (Jegade, 2008; Yitah, 2009; Daniel, 2016; Ayinuola, 2019; Fadare, 2020; Abana & Eke, 2020; Aguoru and Gbadamosi 2022), transformation of proverbs to postproverbials are considered as positive signs of linguistic dynamism, creativity, in-group solidarity, culture and identity markers and, a function of western influence on African youths. What has not been investigated is the variationist tendency of postproverbials. The central concern of this paper is therefore both confirmatory and, then diagnostic. It first seeks to examine the veracity of the existence of postproverbial variations in the language of the youths and then, seeks to determine which of these three frames: culture shift, value shift, or linguistic creativity accounts for the prevalence, form, and reception of postproverbial variations among youths in Southwest Nigeria.

Proverb, Postproverbial and Language Use among the Youths

A number of scholars have described a proverb. According to Finnegan, a proverb is a verbal, concrete realization of "a feeling for language, for imagery, and for the expression of abstract ideas through compressed and allusive phraseology" (1970, p. 390). Boadi

describes the features of proverbs as including “the sharp wit, the sarcasm, the humor, the rhetoric, and . . . all the aesthetic and poetic values of language use” (1972, p. 183). Nnolim sees a proverb as “a recognised truth or shrewd observation about practical life that is ascertained through experience” (1983, p. 36), while Soares (2010, p. 163-164) quoting Mieder (2004) defines a proverb as a “short phrase, usually from the folklore, containing wisdom, truth, morality and traditional perspectives expressed in a metaphorical sense, stable and trainable and transmitted from generation to generation”. Raji-Oyelade perceives a proverb as a pithy and short sentence encapsulating the practical and moral precepts derived from observational and material experiences. Proverbs are “about the history and psychology of the peoples and communities from which they emanate” (1999, p. 74).

The above definitions, in our view, capture the origin and sources of proverbs (tradition, practical experiences, folklore) and discuss the nature of proverbs (witty, shrewd, short). However, the present-day realities would not permit us to agree that proverbs are indeed completely truthful, wisdom-laden and moral. The truth, wisdom and moralistic tendencies of proverbs have been contested by scholars such as Balogun (2010), Daniel (2008) and Oluyamo (2006). Finally, the stability of proverbs as expressed in one of the definitions above becomes doubtful considering the magnitude of transformations proverbs and language in general are going through in the technological age.

Generally speaking, proverbs are sayings that facilitate proper presentation and understanding in discourse. When proverbs are ingeniously deployed in discourse, meanings and understanding are deepened. Proverbs are ubiquitous in African discourse since, traditionally formal (and sometimes informal) interactional encounters in Africa are not complete without the use of proverbs. Yoruba proverbs are sourced from social happenings and lived experiences and they perform a number of functions in interactions, including presenting universal truths, giving advice/warning, garnishing speeches, expressing indirect meanings, coding social norms, settling disputes, among others. Mieder maintains that by “employing proverbs in our speech we wish to strengthen our arguments, express generalisations, influence or manipulate other people, rationalize our own shortcomings, question certain behavioural patterns, satirize social ills, poke fun at ridiculous situations” (1993, p. 11). Thus, an individual versed in the use of proverbs is adjudged a successful interactant.

Raji-Oyelade argues that postproverbials are “inventive and subversive verbal acts” (2014, p. 15), alternate, disruptive but parallel creations produced by deconstructing traditional proverbs. In his definition, Raji-Oyelade describes post-proverbials as playful blasphemies when he writes: “A ‘glottophagic’ process is underway when on the playful tongue of its speaker the traditional proverb loses the sanctity of its structural fixation and gains an elasticity of form all its own” (1999, p. 76). Elsewhere, the author describes the postproverbial as “situated in the subfield of transgressive paremiology, that is the collation, study and interpretation of alternate proverbs which are radical and parallel compositions instead of conventionally accepted and given proverbs in traditional societies” (2012, p. 27). The author is concerned with the perceived rupture of the traditionally fixed proverbs by implying that young ones especially have blasphemed by violating the sanctity of traditional proverbs through postproverbials. Despite the

author's worry, the notion that language is a living and dynamic entity implies that proverbs, a genre of language, cannot continue to be stagnant in an increasingly evolving linguistic landscape.

Therefore, as language evolves, proverbs must evolve. This position is later echoed by Raji-Oyelade that "The emergence of postproverbials is as a result of the interplay of orality and literacy-modernity, the critical correspondence between an older puritanical, a younger disruptive, and somewhat banalistic generation" (2012, p. 10). For Raji-Oyelade, the emergence of these new supplementary proverbs herald "new forms, new meanings, and new values" that signals a "normative rupture" (1999, p. 75). Other scholars (Atanda & Oloruntoba-Oju: 2023; Adebowo & Balogun: 2015; Faturoti: 2021) have attributed the emergence of postproverbials to modernization, punning, societal shift, cultural dynamics, and language evolution.

Distinguishing between the duo, Raji-Oyelade perceives the traditional proverb as being "totally sacrosanct and culturally given... a primary arrangement; its locus is derived from the enduring episteme of the folktales, legends, and myths of traditional societies" while the postproverbial is "culturally dynamic and not expressly rigid ... a *secondary arrangement*, it reacts to the original 'wealth of wisdom' of the traditional proverb by excising its more logical, conclusive part, replacing it with another logic of populist imagination" (1999, p. 77-78). Thus, postproverbial allows for a playful restructuring of the traditional proverb, making postproverbials "parallel, modernist recreations that are derived from and exist side-by-side in rather equal phonocentric status with traditional proverbs" (2012, p. 76). This playful restructuring ultimately causes a pragmatic shock that calls for the renegotiation of meaning.

Our observation in recent time is that aside the fact that proverbs are evolving into postproverbials, postproverbials themselves are also evolving as they are being subjected to variations by the youths. Before now, what scholars have documented in the literature is the relationship and transformation that occur between a proverb and its postproverbial. This is of course, completely different from proverb distortion, which is a product of ignorance. Postproverbials, especially among the youths in southwest Nigeria, are becoming increasingly multivariant. For a proverb, we have observed that youths employ different postproverbials as complements to achieve specific contextual goals in interactions. A proverb may now have two or more postproverbials as complements. This trend seems to have been perceived by Raji-Oyelade (2012, p. 126) when he echoes that "for every popular traditional proverb in use, there is *at least one* postproverbial as its prosthesis" (Emphasis ours). For instance, we have come across proverbs and their postproverbials in these forms:

- 1a. Aitete mole, ole nmoloko.
(Since the thief was not quickly apprehended, they turned round to apprehend the farm owner).
- b. Aitete mole, ole nsalo.
(Since the thief was not quickly apprehended, they started to run away).
- c. Aitete mole, ole ngun fence.
(Since the thief was not quickly apprehended, they started to climb a fence).

It is because of forms such as these that we assume that postproverbials are lending themselves to variations in the hands of the youths in the southwest Nigeria. We therefore wish to interrogate the variations observed and to question the motivations for such variations.

Since its emergence, research on postproverbials has developed substantially. Some of these investigations include: postproverbials and pragmatic implicature in Igbo (Abana & Eke, 2020); gender dynamics in Yoruba postproverbials (Aragbuwa, 2020); social media and Hausa neoproverbs (Adamu, 2023); and corpora issues in proto-proverbials (Atanda & Oloruntoba-Oju, 2023). Some others include: postproverbial irony as cross-cultural (Akinsete, 2024); Nigerian Pidgin postproverbials and social realities (Adeniyi & Ojerinde, 2024) and; translating African postproverbials (Adeyefa, 2024). Postproverbial variations and the possible motivations for postproverbial variations seem not to have been explored. The current research is therefore set to contribute to the literature on postproverbial by interrogating the variations observed in postproverbial and, examining the motivations for postproverbial variations among youths in southwest Nigeria.

Theoretical Framework

Ethnolinguistic Vitality Theory (Ehala 2015) which serves as the theoretical framework for this study leans on Giles and Johnson's (1987) theory of Ethnolinguistic Identity and Ethnolinguistics and, imagines language vitality as a collective entity to preserve language existence through time. The theory posits that two main elements ensure a language survival: Strength and Sustainability. Group strength is the current population of speakers of the language. Group strength implies that members express their kinship to their respective group, since to align close to the group may lead to favouritism. Therefore, the population of the group members will ensure the survival of the language (Ehala, 2015). Group sustainability is the group's attempts to preserve its language. If the group fails to protect its language, it will automatically face extinction. Therefore, if either of the criteria is neglected, the language will face extinction. Language extinction or death occurs when a language has lost its final native speaker or lost both L1 and L2 speakers. A language spoken by elderly generation such as traditional African proverbs may be considered moribund. However, when taken up by youths and creatively transformed as postproverbials to express their peculiar messages and to encode their modern-day world views, culture and identity, it may help to preserve traditional proverbs.

Language death can occur in two ways: Linguicide and glottophagy. Linguicide is the death of a language due to certain causes such as political, natural, or geographical. It is often associated with language discrimination whereby a speaker of a language is discriminated against in terms of wealth, education, and social status. Glottophagy on the other hand is the absorption of a minor language by another dominating language. Zuckermann (2020) explains three ways a language can be revitalised: reclamation, revitalisation and reinvigoration.

We view traditional African proverbs as exclusive preserves of the elders and as a result, they are losing currency among present day Yoruba speakers, especially the youths. To avoid extinction, traditional proverbs need reclamation, revitalization and

reinvigoration. The incursion of postproverbials among the youths function as revitalisation and reinvigoration strategies, a move to connect the old traditional proverbs with the current linguistic trends which blends traditional proverbs with modern creative transformation incorporated in youth culture and identity. We assume that variations in postproverbials will further deepen the revitalization efforts.

Data Collection, Presentation and Analysis

Data consisted of ten (10) Yoruba proverbs selected from common usage in the southwestern part of Nigeria. The proverbs were presented without their completives to 361 participants who are expected to complete them by relying on their knowledge of the proverbs. Proverbs they do not know should be left unanswered. Further, they are to tell the source of the completive part they have provided (from books, elders, social media, etc.). The participants are Yoruba university undergraduates drawn from institutions in the southwest Nigeria, purposively selected due to their assumed exposure to Yoruba proverbs in the course of their schooling, social media interactions, etc. Collected data was presented in the table below, and this is followed by analysis and discussion.

Data Presentation, Analysis and Discussion

Table 4.2: Responses from Proverb, Postproverbial Variations & Motivation Questionnaire

S/N	Complete these proverbs	Compleatives	Total	Tick (✓) the source of the proverbs
1	Àtètè mú olè...	olè nmú olóko. (108) olè nsálo. (171) olè ngun fence. (73)	352	Books (29) Elders (81) Peers (82) Social Media (139) Self (21)
2	Ajá tí yòò sọ̀nù...	kì í gbọ́ ífé ọ̀ḍe (202) kì í gbọ́ notification WhatsApp (68) GPS kò lè se àgbéyọ́rì e` (38) kó lo google map (49)	357	Books (27) Elders (156) Peers (57) Social Media (76) Self (41)
3	Bọ́ mọ̀dè ò kú...	á dà̀gbalàgbà (259) á se birthday (92)	351	Books (143) Elders (106) Peers (47) Social Media (48) Self (7)
4	Màálùù tí kò nírù...	Ọ̀lórùn ló ò bá a lé eșinșin (187) ó pọ́ nì Sábó (165)	352	Books (63) Elders (106) Peers (91) Social Media (74) Self (18)
5	Kò sí ewu lóko...	àfi pìrìrì àparò (203) àfi bandit àti herdsmen (81) àfi pìrìrì invigilator (55)	339	Books (39) Elders (144) Peers (71) Social Media (66) Self (19)
6	Àti gbéyàwó kò tóo pọ́ n...	owó ọ̀bẹ́ ló sòro (231) owó data ló sòro (31) owó bone straight wig ló sòro (23) owó diaper ló sòro (71)	356	Books (62) Elders (113) Peers (52) Social Media (97) Self (32)

7	Ese` yá ju mótò lọ...	ara ló n fàbọ` sí (203) òsì ló n jé bée` (97) poverty ló n jé bée` (51)	351	Books (48) Elders (154) Peers (51) Social Media (79) Self (19)
8	Aboyún mọ oṣù...	kò mọ oṣó (213) scan mọ oṣó (106)	319	Books (43) Elders (125) Peers (46) Social Media (77) Self (28)
9	Eran tí eyín bá já tì...	èékánná kọ` ni yóò já a (84) ni à n pè ní eran námọ` (219)	303	Books (31) Elders (63) Peers (67) Social Media (117) Self (25)
10	A kì í torí jije ra ayékòótọ` sílé...	kí ó ba lè se òfófó aláòsì ni (131) kí ó ba lè serve as gist lover ni (83) kí ó ba lè di monitoring spirit ni (103)	317	Books (33) Elders (92) Peers (71) Social Media (108) Self (13)

Table 4.2 presents the responses to the proverbs. The first column for each number contains the incomplete Yoruba proverb while the second column presents the various completive parts of the proverb as volunteered by respondents. The traditionally correct completive part of the proverb in each case is presented first in the second column, while the others are postproverbials. Further, the total responses for each proverb is in the next column, while the last column shows the respondents' responses on the source or motivation for the completive parts they supplied.

Proverb 1: Àtètè mú olè, olè nmú olóko (Since the thief was not quickly apprehended, they turned round to apprehend the farm owner) has two postproverbials among the youths:

V1: Àtètè mú olè, olè nsálo. (Since the thief was not quickly apprehended, they started to run away)

V2: Àtètè mú olè, olè ngun fence. (Since the thief was not quickly apprehended, they started to climb a fence). In both variants is the notion of urgent escape by the thief as against the notion of unusual boldness on the part of the thief in the traditional proverb, which sees them turning round to apprehend the farm owner. While V1 expresses an escape in the general sense (to run away), V2 expresses an escape through a means which is only peculiar to the present age (climb a fence). The choice of the lexical item through code-switching points to the youths' recognition and infusion of modern realities in the proverb. Of the 352 respondents, only 108 completed the proverb with its traditional completive form while 244 respondents supplied the postproverbials (171 & 73). On the source of the completives, only 110 participants rely on books and elders (29 & 81) while a total of 242 rely on peers (82), social media (139) and self (21). This suggests that although the youths are aware of the traditional proverbs, they rely more on modernisation, youth culture and trends in deploying proverbs.

Proverb 2: Ajá tí yóò sọ̀nù, kì í gbọ́ ́ ifé ọ̀dẹ (A dog destined to be lost does not heed the hunter's whistle) has three postproverbial variations:

V1: Ajá tí yóò sọ̀nù, kì í gbọ́ ́ notification WhatsApp. (A dog destined to be lost does not heed Whatsapp notification).

V2: Ajá tí yóò sọ̀nù, GPS kò lè se àgbéyọ́rí ẹ̀. (A dog destined to be lost, cannot be saved by GPS)

V3: Ajá tí yóò sọ̀nù, kó lo Google map. (A dog destined to be lost should rather seek help from Google map).

The traditional proverb emanates from the traditional hunting experience among the Yoruba where dogs follow the hunter during hunting. A stubborn, heedless and 'destined for loss' dog becomes deaf to the hunter's whistle. Among the youths of today, the traditional hunting experience is strange. They are accustomed to getting social media notifications, using GPS and Google map for information and directions. Therefore, a shift in the culture of the youths from the traditional to the social media-driven modern culture results in the three postproverbial variations. V1 and V2 claim pragmatically that the dog cannot be saved by Whatsapp notification and, even by the GPS since it is stubborn and heedless, while V3 claims that the dog should resort to Google map to find its way home. Therefore, while V1 and V2 echo the same idea of heedlessness as echoed in the traditional proverb, V3 suggests a solution to avoid being lost. The use of V3 seems to be as a result of the shift in the value of the individual speaker. Out of the 357 respondents to this proverb, only 202 opted for the traditional complete, while 155 supplied the three postproverbial variations: V1 68; V2 38 and; V3 49. This pattern suggests that youths are increasingly infusing prevalent youth culture and value in traditional proverbs while striving to maintain creativity. The parallelism observed in P2 and its variants attest to linguistic creativity among the youths. No wonder that 174 respondents claim that the completives they supplied are from peers, social media and self, while 156 got their proverb completives from elders and only 27 from books.

Proverb 3, Bọ́ ́ modé ọ̀ kú, àgbà níí dà (If a child does not die, they attain adulthood) shows only one postproverbial as: V1: Bọ́ ́ modé ọ̀ kú, á se birthday (If a child does not die, they will celebrate their birthday). From a total of 351 respondents, only 92 supply this postproverbial while 259 responds with the traditional complete form. This suggests that a large number of the youths still stick to the traditional proverb while a few of them employ the modern culture-induced postproverbial. While the focus of the traditional proverb is for the surviving child to become an adult (and take up adult responsibilities), the focus of the postproverbial is for the surviving child to celebrate the attainment of a new age. Out of 351 respondents, only 102 claim the sources of their responses are peers (47), social media (48) and self (7) while 106 claim they learn their response from elders and, 143 learn theirs from books.

Just like Proverb 3, Proverb 4, Màálùù tí kò nírù, Ọ̀lórùn ló ń bá a lé eṣinṣin (The tail-less cow relies on God to ward off flies) has only one postproverbial variant among the youths. V1: Màálùù tí kò nírù, ọ̀ pọ̀ ́ ní Sábó (The tail-less cows are many at Sabo market) trivialises a serious proverbial philosophy of God's protection for a helpless person and, replaces it with the notion that such helplessness is common place. It says

that ‘tail-less cows are many at Sabo’ (Hausa settlements and markets) to trivialise the issue as those in the category are many. From the 352 respondents, almost half supplies this postproverbial as their completive form while 187 completed the proverb in its traditional form. Similarly, 183 participants claim the knowledge of the proverbs from peers (91), social media (74) and self (18).

Proverb 5: *Kò sí ewu lóko àfi pìrìrì àparò* (There is no danger in the farm, except for the flight of partridges) has two postproverbial variants:

V1: *Kò sí ewu lóko àfi bandits àti herdsmen* (There is no danger in the farm, except for banditry and herdsmen attacks).

V2: *Kò sí ewu lóko àfi pìrìrì invigilator* (There is no danger in the farm, except for the invigilators’ vigilance).

We observe that 203 respondents supply the completive form in the traditional proverbs while 136 supply the two variants; V1 is 81 while V2 is 55. V1 apparently points to the current challenges of banditry and herdsmen attacks facing the country as the only danger in the farm. V2 is more personal to the respondents as it points to the activities of strict invigilators during examinations as the only danger in the farm and, farm in the context of V2 implies examination halls. The above implies that a lot of the respondents are quite familiar with the traditional proverb but some, intending to code issues that are current and personal resort to the postproverbials. No wonder that while many of the 339 respondents learnt the proverbs from elders (144) and books (39), we still have many who learnt it from peers (71), social media (66) and (self) 19.

Proverb 6: *Àti gbéyàwó kò tóó pọ́n owó ọbẹ́ ló ọ̀rọ* (Getting married is not the issue, providing regular upkeep is the problem) has three postproverbial variants:

V1: *Àti gbéyàwó kò tóó pọ́n owó data ló ọ̀rọ* (Getting married is not the issue, providing regular data is the problem).

V2: *Àti gbéyàwó kò tóó pọ́n owó bone straight wig ló ọ̀rọ* (Getting married is not the issue, providing bone straight wigs is the problem).

V3: *Àti gbéyàwó kò tóó pọ́n owó diaper ló ọ̀rọ* (Getting married is not the issue, providing regular diaper is the problem).

Like the previous proverb, the responses here show that participants recognise the traditional proverb as 231 out of the 356 respondents supply the traditional answer to the proverb. Only 125 respondents opt for the postproverbial variants: V1 is 31; V2 is 23 and V3 is 71. The 125 respondents are apparently influenced by contemporary and personal issues as they make references to data, bone straight wig and diaper, rather than a broader subject of upkeep which is the focus of the traditional proverb. The sources of their responses include books (62), elders (113), peers (52), social media (97) and self (32), suggesting that while the youths are aware of the traditional proverbs, they are influenced by contemporary youth culture and values, as well as linguistic habits.

Proverb 7: *Èsẹ̀ yá ju mótò lo ara ló ń fàbọ̀ sí* (Trekking when you can go by car wears the body down) shows evidence of two postproverbial variants:

V1: Eṣe` yá ju mótò lo ọ̀sì ló ń jé bée` (Trekking when you can go by car is a sign of poverty).

V2: Eṣe` yá ju mótò lo poverty ló ń jé bée` (Trekking when you can go by car is a sign of poverty).

The postproverbial variants are actually the same, except for the lexical item 'poverty' rendered in English in V2. This is a result of codeswitching and evidence of linguistic creativity among the respondents. Out of 351 respondents, a large number (203) completed the proverb with its traditional completive form while 148 supply the postproverbial forms, with 97 of them using the V1 and 51 using the V2. Further, 48 respondents learnt the proverb from books, 154 learnt it from elders, 51 from peers, 79 from the social media while 19 claims they made it up. The respondents, therefore, understands the traditional proverb, but resort to the postproverbials to encode their youthful experiences and preferences for stress-free life in wealth and abundance.

Proverb 8: Aboyún mọ ọ̀ṣu, kò mọ ọ́jó (The expectant mother could tell the month but not the day) has only a postproverbial:

V1: Aboyún mọ ọ̀ṣu, scan mọ ọ́jó (The expectant mother could tell the month, scan could tell the day).

More respondents (213) completed the proverb with the traditional form, suggesting that the respondents are largely aware of the traditional form. Others (106) who completed it with the postproverbial form echo their belief in modern technology through the postproverbial. Of the 319 respondents, 43 learnt the proverbs from books, 125 from elders, 46 from peers and, 77 from the social media, while 28 claim they created it.

Proverb 9: Eran tí eyín bá já tí èékánná kọ́ ní yóò já a (A piece of meat too tough for the teeth is beyond the nails' tackle) has only a postproverbial:

V1: Eran tí eyín bá já tí ni à ń pè ní eran námo` (A piece of meat too tough for the teeth is called 'námo`).

While the traditional proverb philosophically posits that a task difficult for a professional or veteran cannot be left for a non-professional, the postproverbial rather focuses on the special name jocularly given to very tough pieces of meat among some Yoruba. The Hausa term, 'námo`' means meat but the Yoruba especially the youths, extend its semantics to include tough meat. This completive postproverbial is so common that 219 out of 303 participants respond with the postproverbial while only 84 opt for the traditional completive form. On its sources, out of 303 respondents, 117 got the proverb from the social media, 67 got it from peers and 25 claim it was made up by themselves. Only 94 respondents agree that the proverb completives come from books (31) and elders (63).

Proverb 10: A kì í torí jíjẹ ra ayékòótọ́ sílẹ́, kí ó ba lẹ ẹ ọ́fọ́fọ́ aláábòsì ní (The parrot is not kept as a table bird, but as a spy on snooping neighbours) shows evidence of two postproverbials:

- V1: A kù í torí jìje ra ayékòótó sílé, kí ó ba lè serve as gist lover ni (The parrot is not kept as a table bird, but as a gist partner)
 V2: A kù í torí jìje ra ayékòótó sílé, kí ó ba lè di monitoring spirit ni (The parrot is not kept as a table bird, but for surveillance).

The traditional proverb has it that the reason for keeping a parrot is for it to spy on people around and report their activities to its owner. However, V1 maintains that the reason for keeping a parrot is for it to serve as a gist partner, a gossip mate while V2 maintains that the reason for keeping a parrot is for the purpose of surveillance. It is observed that the message in V1 completely deviated from the sense spying on others as expressed in the traditional proverb. V1 rather favours the sense of gossip, information and tale carrying which is common among the youths and further enhanced by social media blogs. V2 redirects its semantic focus to the message similar to the one echoed in the traditional proverb but uttered in the modern language of the youths (kí ó ba lè di monitoring spirit = for surveillance), that parrots are kept for surveillance, as spies and informants. Out of the 317 respondents, 186 supplied the post proverbia (V1 is 83 & V2 is 103) while only 131 completed the proverb with the traditional form. This implies that many of the youths prefer the postproverbial completive forms as the forms speak more to their interest and experiences (love of gist, information, gossip and surveillance). Similarly in completing the proverb, about 200 respondents claim that they rely on motivation from peers (71), social media (108) and self (13), while only 33 and 92 respondents rely on books and elders respectively.

Findings and Conclusion

The study has analysed ten incomplete proverbs in order to interrogate postproverbial variations and the motivations for postproverbial variations among youths in Southwest Nigeria. Analysis of responses from the ten incomplete proverbs presented to 361 Yoruba-speaking participants reveals that postproverbials vary as some of the data show evidence of two postproverbials (proverbs 1, 5, 7 and 10) while some others show evidence of three postproverbials (proverbs 2 and 6) from certain traditional proverbs. Analysis also establishes that the observed variations are socio-pragmatically motivated as the completives are used to express current, modern and peculiar social realities of respondents in a creative manner. Postproverbial variations occur because youths rely heavily on social and electronic media, peers and personal ingenuity as sources of the knowledge of the proverbs, though a number of them still rely on elders and books. This is clearly shown in the data as many of the youths complete the proverbs by relying on peers, social media and self. For instance, 242 respondents in example 1, 174 respondents in example 2 and, 209 respondents in example 9 claim to rely on peers, social media and self. It is further discovered that postproverbials are heavily influenced by trendy youth culture (use of modern youth-centric words, neologism, foreign words, coding personalised experiences, playful references) and by individual preferences of the speaker in specific socio-pragmatic contexts, while its formation shows profuse evidence of linguistic creativity such as parallelism and codeswitching. The paper reasons that postproverbials and postproverbial variations, heavily motivated by popular youth cultures and moderately motivated by constant shifts in the individual values of the

youths, are gaining grounds as strong markers of youth identity as they function to sustain and preserve the language and its proverbs. The paper concludes that the youths' relationships with proverbs are influenced by the tradition, the modern life and the social media.

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